CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

Saturday, October 24, 2026

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RE: NZ defence chief resigns over relationship · Vanuatu 6.9 quake, tsunami warning cancelled · PNG parliament to vote on Bougainville in November · AUKUS Pillar 2 autonomy trials off California · Rabuka denies constitution bill extends his term

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
8,795	0.7038	13,734	0.5701
-0.13%	+0.95%	-0.14%	+0.74%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · Pacific · New Zealand · China-Pacific · Canberra · Markets · Documents · Upcoming · The Wire

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. New Zealand's Chief of Defence Force Tony Davies resigned after admitting an inappropriate relationship, two weeks out from the November 7 general election.
2. Papua New Guinea's national parliament will vote in November on the constitutional amendment required to give effect to Bougainville's 97.7 percent independence referendum result, with the government saying a three-quarters majority is needed.
3. AUKUS partners are running Maritime Big Play Pacific off Southern California from October 5 to 26, testing more than 40 crewed and uncrewed technologies under Pillar 2, with the Royal Navy leading the anti-submarine warfare element.

TOP STORIES

NZ-DEFENSE

New Zealand's military chief resigns after admitting inappropriate relationship

New Zealand's Chief of Defence Force **Tony Davies** resigned after admitting to an inappropriate relationship. The departure lands two weeks before the general election on November 7, with Minister of Defence **Judith Collins** and her coalition partners in caretaker-adjacent campaign mode.

per Washington Post: "New Zealand's military chief resigns after admitting to an inappropriate relationship"

PACIFIC-POLITICS

PNG parliament to vote in November on Bougainville independence

Papua New Guinea's national parliament will vote in November on the constitutional change arising from Bougainville's referendum, which recorded *97.7 percent* for independence. Constitutional amendments ordinarily require a two-thirds majority, but the government says Bougainville independence requires three-quarters of members. Prime Minister **James Marape** addressed the Bougainville reports in parliament; member for Sinesine-Yongomugl and former attorney-general **Kerenga Kua** voiced the concerns many members hold, with some arguing the question should go to all PNG voters in a national referendum.

per ABC Pacific: "PNG Palamen bai vout long Bougainville independence long Novemba"

AUKUS

AUKUS partners run autonomy demonstration off Southern California

Maritime Big Play Pacific runs from October 5 to 26 off Southern California, testing *more than 40 technologies* from government and industry across the three AUKUS partners under Pillar 2. The Royal Navy leads the anti-submarine warfare element, bringing uncrewed surface vessels, underwater gliders, drones and subsea vehicles. **Michael Dodd**, assistant secretary of the Department of War for critical technologies, said the programme was assessing scenarios involving autonomous systems from "seafloor to space".

per Naval Technology: "AUKUS partners test autonomous maritime systems off California" · also ADS Advance

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Rabuka rejects claims constitutional amendments extend his term

Prime Minister **Sitiveni Rabuka** dismissed speculation that the Constitution (Amendment) Bill 2026 is aimed at prolonging his time in office, telling consultations on Rotuma the government is fulfilling an election promise to amend the 2013 Constitution. The bill needs a two-thirds majority at third reading before proceeding to a referendum; if that threshold is missed, the process ends. Rabuka said the work had to be completed within the term of the current parliament, which first sat on February 6, 2023.

per Fiji Sun: "PM Rabuka rejects claims of power extension"

OVERNIGHT

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Tsunami warning cancelled after large earthquake off Vanuatu · RNZ

A quake initially put at magnitude 7.2 and later revised by the USGS to 6.9 struck about 200 kilometres north-west of Port Olry at 12:31pm AEST, followed five minutes later by a 6.3 event. Both were at 10 kilometres depth. The Vanuatu Geological Hazards Department said sea level and observational data showed no remaining tsunami threat to Vanuatu's coastal areas. The Bureau of Meteorology issued no threat for Australia.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Vanuatu initiates arbitration proceedings against France · Vanuatu Daily Post

Vanuatu has begun arbitration proceedings against France, the Vanuatu Daily Post reported. The outlet carried no further detail in the text available.

AU-POLITICS

Steele-John publishes then deletes letter detailing allegations against him · ABC News

Jordon Steele-John published on social media a three-page letter marked confidential, addressed to Greens leader **David Shoebridge** and signed by seven current and former Greens staff or office bearers, then deleted it. Dated October 13, the letter cites "multiple allegations of serious misconduct" concerning his behaviour around women spanning 2017 to 2025. He denies the allegations and will not attend parliament next week; the WA Greens have commissioned an independent investigation.

AU-POLITICS

Steele-John says attending estimates virtually was ruled 'unacceptable' · Guardian Australia

The WA senator said he had considered attending Senate estimates virtually but was told that would be "unacceptable", Guardian Australia's **Sarah Basford Canales** reported. He apologised for publicly releasing the letter outlining the claims against him.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

AFP equips Vanuatu police posts under Nakamal Agreement · Vanuatu Daily Post

The Australian Federal Police has supplied computers, satellite internet technology and generators to the Vanuatu Police Force's Criminal Records Office and *eighteen provincial police posts*, to speed Police Clearance Certificate services outside urban centres. AFP Senior Responsible Officer in Vanuatu Superintendent **Alex Middlemiss** said the work falls under the Nakamal Agreement and that improving rural access to policing is a priority of the Vanuatu-Australia partnership.

AU-POLITICS

Canberra adds $10 million for flood-damaged Cloncurry Airport · Xinhua

The federal government announced a further *$10 million* to upgrade Cloncurry Airport in north-west Queensland, damaged by flooding in late 2025 and early 2026. The commitment builds on $11.5 million previously provided jointly with the Queensland government for emergency repairs. Minister for Infrastructure, Transport, Regional Development and Local Government **Catherine King** said the funding would keep the airport supporting aeromedical transport and mining operations.

STAT OF THE DAY

97.7%

Bougainville referendum vote for independence

PNG's national parliament votes in November on the constitutional change, with the government saying three-quarters of members must support it.

ABC Pacific

PACIFIC WIRE

COOK ISLANDS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Cook Islands parliament unlikely to sit until 2027

No hearing dates have been set for the outstanding electoral petitions with just over a week left in October, while the court registry maintains hearings will fall next month. On that timetable parliament is unlikely to sit before 2027.

REGIONAL · FIJI SUN

Twenty-two Pacific NGOs demand Israel's Forum partnership be suspended

The Pacific Regional Non-Governmental Organisations Alliance, including the Pacific Conference of Churches, Oxfam in the Pacific and the Fiji Women's Crisis Centre, called on Forum leaders to suspend Israel's newly approved partner status and urged Fiji, Papua New Guinea and Nauru to move their embassies from Jerusalem to Tel Aviv. "We cannot invoke the Court for our islands and ignore it for Palestine," the alliance said, citing the International Court of Justice's July 2024 advisory opinion.

FIJI · FIJIVILLAGE

Sayed-Khaiyum urges halt to Fiji's Constitution Amendment Bill

Former attorney-general **Aiyaz Sayed-Khaiyum** told the joint parliamentary select committee in Labasa that the bill contains grammatical errors, incorrect cross-references and ambiguous provisions. He singled out Clause 211, which lets the President bring the amendments into force early by proclamation despite a stated commencement of 31 March 2028, and argued it conflicts with Section 166 of the 2013 Constitution.

FIJI · FIJIVILLAGE

SODELPA will not support third reading of Constitution Amendment Bill

SODELPA has said it will not support the Constitution (Amendment) Bill at its third reading. The bill requires a two-thirds parliamentary majority at that stage to proceed to a referendum.

SAMOA · SAMOA OBSERVER

Samoa's police commissioner appointment tests the recruitment process

Samoa has gone more than a year without a permanent Police Commissioner. Sources told the Samoa Observer that Superintendent **Fata William Fanene**, serving with the New Zealand Police, ranked first in interviews, and Prime Minister **La'aulialemalietoa Leuatea Schmidt** confirmed an overseas candidate came out on top while saying Cabinet wanted someone already in the ministry given the chance to lead.

VANUATU · VANUATU DAILY POST

Vanuatu teachers' strike heads to trial on November 24

Judge **Maree MacKenzie** set trial for 9:30am on November 24 to determine the lawfulness of the Vanuatu Teachers Union's industrial action, reserving her ruling on the State's interlocutory application to stay it. The State must file its defence by October 30 and is seeking a declaration that the VTU breached the Collective Bargaining Agreement and this year's Memorandum of Conciliation.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

PNG deputy opposition leader questions centralising tax credit approvals

Member for Hiri-Koiari and Deputy Opposition Leader **Keith Iduhu** questioned in parliament the government's move to centralise all Infrastructure Tax Credit approvals in Port Moresby, warning it could delay projects in rural and resource-hosting communities.

COOK ISLANDS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Cook Islands cuts immigration fees and extends Australian visitor stays

The Cook Islands has cut immigration fees and extended permitted stays for Australian visitors to lift tourism, prompting debate over the effect on an already tight supply of affordable local housing.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Cikobia Island still short of water after emergency delivery

A National Disaster Risk Management Office delivery of bottled water, sanitary hampers and a 5,000-litre tank by MLC Vatulawa is insufficient for Cikobia's four villages, island representative **Apaitia Cagituevei** said. He said successive governments had promised to resolve the island's recurring dry-season water scarcity, which also affects its only school and only nursing station.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-DEFENSE · NZ HERALD

Ex-NZSAS commander says Defence Force has lost its fighting edge

Former NZSAS commander **Bernard Isherwood** said the New Zealand Defence Force has lost its fighting edge through what he believes are failures of leadership and management. The NZ Herald reported the criticism alongside NZ First's **Ron Mark** saying he would remove the current leadership.

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

National pledges financial literacy in schools under 'Plan for Parents'

Christopher Luxon released National's 'Plan for Parents' policy in Auckland, which includes adding financial literacy to the school curriculum. Advance voting opens on October 26 ahead of the November 7 election.

NZ-POLITICS · THE POST

Greens and Labour locked in tight Wellington North race, Opportunities on 13 percent

Polling in Wellington North shows the Green Party and Labour closely matched, with The Opportunities Party on *13 percent*.

NZ-POLITICS · THE POST

Hipkins demands Luxon act against National MP over gang photograph

Labour leader **Chris Hipkins** called on Christopher Luxon to take action against a National MP pictured with gang members, two weeks from polling day.

NZ-POLITICS · 1NEWS

Immigration NZ pauses deportation of Tongan children after failures

Immigration New Zealand paused the deportation of two children and the aunt raising them, admitting officers failed to check key information about the family's circumstances. 1News reported four Tongan children were left traumatised by the attempt.

CHINA IN THE PACIFIC

SOLOMON ISLANDS · FISHERIES / MARITIME · ABC PACIFIC

Solomon Islands takes ownership of confiscated Chinese cargo ship

The Solomon Islands government has taken ownership of the Chinese cargo vessel MV Wealth, confiscated after it entered national waters unlawfully in June. A Solomon Islands patrol boat made the arrest in an operation involving several government agencies and partners including the Forum Fisheries Agency. About 20 Asian nationals from the vessel appeared in court on Monday and are on bail at Rove pending a further appearance next week.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Taylor rejects link between robust debate and political violence

Opposition Leader **Angus Taylor** said he disagrees with the connection some parliamentarians are drawing between robust political debate and political violence, and that the Westminster system is not to blame and does not need to be altered. Some MPs and senators have called for changes to Question Time in the wake of the attack on independent MP **Helen Haines**, whose condition has improved to serious but stable.

AU-POLITICS · THE NEW DAILY

Vigils held across Australia and in London for Helen Haines

Candlelight vigils were held at 8pm on Friday in Victoria and around the country, with Haines' constituents also gathering at Australia House in London. The independent MP is in a critical but stable condition at The Alfred Hospital after having both legs amputated. Constituent **Brendan Nugent**, 43, has been charged with three offences related to the incident.

AU-POLITICS · GUARDIAN AUSTRALIA

Haines attack overshadowed her own signature reform, McIlroy writes

Guardian Australia's **Tom McIlroy** notes the Wangaratta attack fell on the same day the attorney-general announced a new head for the National Anti-Corruption Commission, the body Haines forced onto the political agenda and helped design and oversee. He writes that for many in parliament, particularly women, the arrival of violence in Australian politics has been long expected.

AU-POLITICS · ABC POLITICS

Cormann calls on Albanese government to reform the tax system

OECD Secretary-General and former finance minister **Mathias Cormann** said the cost-of-living crunch is fuelling frustration and pulling voters towards populist parties. Speaking to David Speers from Paris, he called on the Albanese government to reform the tax system.

AU-POLITICS · THE NEW DAILY

Fact check finds Butler wrong on Coalition tobacco enforcement record

Health Minister **Mark Butler** told parliament in September that tobacco excise rose 215 percent under the Coalition and "they trousered every single dollar", with nothing going to enforcement or public health campaigns. The Coalition did increase funding to crack down on illicit tobacco, including launching the Illicit Tobacco Taskforce in 2018, and while it cut anti-tobacco advertising it raised funding for a program to reduce Indigenous smoking rates.

AU-POLITICS · POLITICO

Politico: Australia's wish for a kinder politics looks set to disappoint

Politico's Canberra Playbook argues Australia's hope for a kinder, gentler politics after this week's events seems doomed to disappointment.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

Backpackers say visa changes strip the incentive for regional work

Changes taking effect over the next 12 months will significantly reduce working holiday visa numbers and introduce a ballot system, removing the guarantee of a second year in exchange for *88 days* of regional work. Irish backpacker **Meghan Morris**, working at De Bortoli wines in the NSW Riverina, said the work is only done for the visa. Growers say the changes will hit food production over the summer harvest.

TRADE-ECONOMY · PNG POST-COURIER

K92 Mining pays K231 million third corporate tax instalment in PNG

K92 Mining Ltd said it has paid *K231 million* to Papua New Guinea's Internal Revenue Commission as its third and final scheduled corporate tax instalment for 2026.

TRADE-ECONOMY · FIJI SUN

Fiji resort warns water insecurity could force a $700,000 guest evacuation

InterContinental Fiji Golf Resort and Spa director of engineering **David Hayes** told HOTEC 2026 that unreliable water and power could force the 266-room Natadola property to evacuate guests and rehouse them at a cost

exceeding *$700,000*. The resort consumes more than 300,000 litres of water a day against 1.5 million litres of storage, and ran 89 percent occupancy for the year.

PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

MINISTERIAL TRANSCRIPT · AUSTRALIAN MINISTER FOR FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Wong announces Ambassador for Arms Control and Counter-Proliferation

Penny Wong issued a media release announcing an Ambassador for Arms Control and Counter-Proliferation. The release text available carries no further detail.

MINISTERIAL TRANSCRIPT · AUSTRALIAN MINISTER FOR FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Wong announces Ambassador for Cyber Affairs, AI and Critical Technology

A second media release from the foreign minister announces an Ambassador for Cyber Affairs, Artificial Intelligence and Critical Technology. The two appointments were published together.

UPCOMING

OCT 26

Advance voting opens in the New Zealand general election

Voting begins with the Defence Force leadership vacant after the Chief of Defence Force's resignation.

OCT 2026

Australian parliament resumes, with Senate estimates and Jordon Steele-John absent

The Greens' handling of the misconduct allegations becomes a parliamentary question with the senator off the floor.

NOV 5

Wotta murder case mention, High Court in Lautoka

Fiji's High Court takes carriage of a case transferred from the Nadi Magistrate Court on public interest grounds.

NOV 7

New Zealand general election

Determines whether the National, ACT and NZ First coalition continues to set Wellington's defence and Pacific policy.

NOV 24

Vanuatu Teachers Union industrial action trial, Port Vila

The court will rule on whether the teachers' strike is lawful, with the State seeking to have it called off.

THE WIRE

PACIFIC-POLITICS

COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Climate-resilient upgrade underway at Mauke Hospital

Work has begun to strengthen Mauke Hospital against climate impacts, part of a wider programme to build more resilient health facilities across the Cook Islands.

PNG POST-COURIER

Ok Tedi Mining airlifts 14 tonnes of El Nino relief to Tabubil

Ok Tedi Mining Limited supported the transport of *14 tonnes* of El Nino relief supplies to Tabubil in North Fly District. Separately, the Tuloun Community Government is coordinating relief for Carteret Islands communities facing prolonged El Nino heat.

FIJIVILLAGE

NFP president says constitution consultation 'makes a mockery of democracy'

The National Federation Party president criticised the conduct of public consultations on Fiji's Constitution (Amendment) Bill 2026.

FBC NEWS

Kamikamica challenges critics to point to racist provisions in draft

Deputy Prime Minister **Manoa Kamikamica** challenged critics of Fiji's proposed constitutional reforms to identify any provision they consider racist, saying the draft is an inclusive document intended to address longstanding problems with the 2013 Constitution.

TRADE-ECONOMY

UNITED STATES STUDIES CENTRE

A $3 billion downgrade could send a ripple through a surging Australian industry

The United States Studies Centre examines a $3 billion downgrade and its potential effects on a fast-growing Australian industry.

NZ-POLITICS

RNZ

RNZ runs live coverage of the New Zealand campaign trail

RNZ's political editor **Jo Moir** and deputy editor **Craig McCulloch** are running daily live coverage through to election day on November 7.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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